

WHAT IF?

TEXT: Mark 12:41-44 (NKJV) *“Now Jesus sat opposite the treasury and saw how the people put money into the treasury. And many who were rich put in much. 42 Then one poor widow came and threw in two mites. 43 So He called His disciples to Himself and said to them, “Assuredly, I say to you that this poor widow has put in more than all those who have given to the treasury; 44 for they all put in out of their abundance, but she out of her poverty put in all that she had, her whole livelihood.”*

INTRO: Today is Harvest Sunday. Harvest Sunday is the one day a year that we have set aside at CT Church to ask for two things:

- 1) 100% participation in tithing.
- 2) Each family will tithe, not on what they are currently making, but on what they want to be making at this time next year.

When the Children of Israel came into Canaan, they gave a first fruits offering, which was an

over-and-above offering from the first crops they produced in Canaan. The Harvest Offering was a kind of pay it forward by faith offering. It was an act of faith that God was going to do what He had promised to do in turning the land into “*A land that flowed with milk and honey.*”

The Harvest Offering was the ignition switch that engaged the blessing of the Lord.

Our offering today is intended to ignite the blessing of the Lord for the next 12 months. Get ready! Get set!... Ladies and gentlemen, start your engines...

WHAT IF MONEY IS A TEST?

Prayer is the currency of Heaven, and it is absolutely essential in the life of the believer. Money is the currency of the earth!

Salvation is FREE, but it requires resources to live day-to-day and do the work of the Kingdom in the earth.

ILLUSTRATION:

A guy brought his family to church and as they were driving home afterwards, he was complaining about everything. He said, *“The music was too loud. The sermon was too long, the announcements were unclear, the building was hot, and the people were unfriendly...”* He went on and on, complaining about virtually everything. Finally, his very observant son said, *“Dad, you’ve got to admit, it wasn’t a bad show for just a dollar.”*

Whether today, on Harvest Sunday, or any other day, our giving cannot be to the church, it must be to The Lord of The Church! We aren't giving to man; we are giving to GOD. It's a form of worship.

Generosity always comes from a heart of thankfulness. (This is Thanks-Giving – not Thanks-Getting week!

Stinginess leads to poverty and theft. Let's look to a Biblical example of generosity. An overlooked fact about the story of the woman with the alabaster jar of perfume is played out in John 12:41-8 (NKJV) ***“But one of His disciples, Judas Iscariot, Simon’s son, who would betray Him, said, 5 “Why was this fragrant oil not sold for three hundred denarii and given to the poor?” 6 This he said, not that he cared for the poor, but because he was a thief, and had the money box; and he used to take what was put in it. 7 But Jesus said, “Let her alone; she has kept this for the day of My burial. 8 For the poor you have with you always, but Me you do not have always.”***

Mary had been forgiven by Jesus, and she lavished Her love on Him. She gave Him the equivalent of one year’s wages. Can you imagine taking what you've earned in one year and giving it in a single offering? That is what Mary did in this passage of Scripture.

Judas, a disciple of Christ, got mad. He said it should have been sold, and given to the poor. The Bible says he didn't care for the poor, but ***“his hand was in the bag!!!!”***

This guy was taking money out of the offering receptacle! He was guilty of embezzlement! He was a thief! Can we agree on that?

What if there was a person sitting on the row with you, that you notice was taking money out, rather than putting money in, every Sunday morning?

- Would that make you crazy?
- Would you confront him?
- Would you say something to Pastor Blake?
- Would you say something to a Board Member?
- Would you report it to me?

Of course! Why? Your conscience would not

allow you to let a thief continue without being held accountable!

Jesus said Judas was, “*a thief.*”

Who chose Judas? Who put Judas over the money? Jesus! Did Jesus know Judas was going to go bad? Of course, He is all knowing! He said earlier that he had “*chosen twelve, and one was a devil!*”

Was Jesus setting him up to fail? Perhaps, He was setting him up to succeed!

Jesus set Judas up to pass the money test! It was the point of Judas' greatest weakness, if he could get past this, everything else would come easy for him.

What is the money test? And how can we pass it? Money is the one thing we all have in common and we are all tested with it every week of our lives. Can we be faithful with it? Can we be trusted with it? Can we manage it? Do we work for it, or does it work for us? If we can't be faithful with money, how can God trust us with spiritual things?

Jesus said Judas was a thief for taking out, but Malachi said we become thieves if we don't put enough in!

We just agreed that we would not sit idly by, while

someone took money out of the offering receptacle. But what about those who do not place an adequate amount IN the offering receptacle? They are embezzlers and thieves as well! Not by my measurement, but by the measurement of the Word of God!

Money magnifies our character!

- A person who is unfaithful with a little money will be out of control with a lot of money!
- A drug addict and alcoholic will beg, borrow, and steal everything they can, to fuel their addiction! If they come into an enormous amount of money, they won't check themselves into the best drug and alcohol recovery center in America, that money becomes fuel on the fire!
- A person who steals money from their employer to provide for their family, will steal more if they are given more accessibility, even though they have more than enough already!

Money doesn't develop character, it reveals

character! Those who are faithful with a little, will be faithful with much.

Faithfulness is a decision; generosity is something that has to be taught and learned.

We must realize that as a Christian, our financial situations are both a faith and a trust issue.

WHAT IF THE PASTOR WAS WATCHING WHAT WE GIVE?

What if it was necessary for everyone to come to the front to give? What if we were required to show the pastor what we were giving, BEFORE they gave it? What if the pastor had the authority to decide whether the offering was acceptable or unacceptable? What if the pastor had the obligation to engage us publicly for our giving?

Would that change our giving in any way?

Don't panic! I am not suggesting we move to this model, but the truth is, in the Old Testament the people were to bring their offering to the Priest in

a very public way, and he was to examine it and decide whether it was a worthy sacrifice or not!

Trust me, they didn't have a sheep pen strategically located behind the Temple in an obscure area, to protect the anonymity of the gifts and sacrifices the people brought.

I'm sure some of you are thinking; what about ***“doing your alms giving in secret”***? That was speaking of what one did with over and above giving, such as taking care of the poor. In other words what was being said there was, ***“Don't go out and give \$20 to the guy under the bridge and post 239 pictures on Facebook lauding your acts of generosity.”*** When we do things like this, we have received all the reward we will ever get.

When folks were bringing their tithe and first-fruit to the Lord, someone had to inspect it before it could be received. The rich rancher couldn't pull up on the Temple parking lot in his Rolls Royce chariot and leave 12 flea-bitten, lame

lambs, and expect that to be good enough.

Our text finds Jesus sitting in the synagogue
EXAMINING the gifts of the people!

Jesus was watching! (Story about “*Jesus is watching you.*”) As Jesus watched:

- He was asking questions...
- He was making comments...
- He was utilizing facial expressions...
- He was employing body language...

I suspect people would be very uncomfortable for the pastor to examine each gift before it was given, but know this, Jesus is watching! And He knows:

- Whether we spend more on our mortgage than we give...
- Whether we spend more on vacations than we give...
- Whether we spend more on our car payments than we give...
- Whether we spend more on our kids’ education and sporting activities than we

give...

God is okay with us having a Rolls Royce lifestyle, and so am I. But neither of us is okay with a Rolls Royce life that is accompanied by skateboard giving patterns.

WHAT IF JESUS MADE DISTINCTIONS IN GIVING?

The western church has been conditioned to believe that there are no distinctions in giving. There is no small gift as compared to a large gift. We have been led to believe that God sees all givers alike. Does He?

Let's look at our text again... Mark 12:41-44 (NKJV) *“Now Jesus sat opposite the treasury and saw how the people put money into the treasury. And many who were rich put in much. 42 Then one poor widow came and threw in two mites. 43 So He called His disciples to Himself and said to them, “Assuredly, I say to you that this poor widow has put in more than all those who have given to the treasury; 44 for they all*

put in out of their abundance, but she out of her poverty put in all that she had, her whole livelihood.”

In this passage, Jesus distinguishes between:

- Little and much...
- The rich and the poor...
- The haves and the have nots...
- Big gifts and little gifts...
- Generous gifts and stingy gifts...

What if The Pastor distinguished between the value of gift's? Most of us would have heartburn with that. I am not suggesting we do that, but this I can assure us; Jesus is distinguishing between them! And, not just on Harvest Sunday, but every day of the week, every week of the year.

There are three kinds of givers:

- Flint-Givers – To get anything out of a flint, one must hammer it. At its best, you only get chips and sparks!
- Sponge-Givers – To get what is in a sponge to come out, you have to squeeze it. The

more pressure you put on a sponge, the more you get out of it.

- Honeycomb-Givers – A honeycomb continuously drips with its own sweetness. If you take the honey from the honeycomb, it will have replenished it when you return.

What kind of givers are we going to be?

WHAT IF WE ALL GAVE GENEROUSLY?

2 Corinthians 9:5-8 (NKJV) *“Therefore I thought it necessary to exhort the brethren to go to you ahead of time, and prepare your generous gift beforehand, which you had previously promised, that it may be ready as a matter of generosity and not as a grudging obligation.*

⁶ But this I say: He who sows sparingly will also reap sparingly, and he who sows bountifully will also reap bountifully. ⁷ So let each one give as he purposes in his heart, not grudgingly or of necessity; for God loves a cheerful giver.

⁸ And God is able to make all grace abound toward you, that you, always having all

sufficiency in all things, may have an abundance for every good work.”

Most people think this passage is about giving, but it is really about generosity. Paul writes to the Corinthian Church and tells them he is about to come for a visit and that there is a better than good chance, he will be bringing some of the Macedonian people with him. Paul had spent the better part of the previous year ministering in Macedonia and while teaching there he had evidently used the generosity of the Corinthians as an example to the Macedonians.

I find this quite interesting, even comical, Paul writes this letter to the Corinthians prior to his arrival BECAUSE he doesn't want what he has boasted to the Macedonians about the Corinthians, to become a train wreck. LOL

Paul challenges the Corinthians to move beyond haphazard giving to generosity!

- Giving requires no forethought – Generosity is the result of strategic preparation“***Prepare***

your generous gifts beforehand.”

- Giving is sometimes done out of obligation. Generosity is done out of a desire to connect to the vision. Paul says our giving should be ***“a matter of generosity and not a grudging obligation.”***
- Giving has the characteristics of ***sparingly sowing!*** Generosity is marked by ***bountifully sowing and reaping.***
- God blesses givers, but He ***Loves generosity.***

Verse 8 tells us what would happen if we were to all give generously. ***“God is able to make all grace abound toward you, that you, ALWAYS having ALL SUFFICIENCY in ALL THINGS, may have an ABUNDANCE for EVERY GOOD WORK.”***

What if we all gave generously?

- Our personal finances would increase...
- Our generational wealth would be

expanded...

- Our paths would drip with abundance...
- Kingdom projects would be funded...
- Kingdom influence would increase...

What if all American Christians tithed 10%? The church would have an additional \$165 Billion dollars-worth of resources to distribute. The church could become what Christ intended. The government could go out of the business of providing social justice for its citizens, and the

church could become the hands and feet of Jesus.

If all American Christians tithed 10% of their total income:

- \$25 Billion dollars could be used to resolve global hunger, starvation and deaths from preventable diseases. This could happen in five years.
- \$12 Billion would eliminate illiteracy!!!
- \$15 Billion would solve the worlds water and sanitation problems.
- \$1 Billion would fund all overseas missions

efforts!!!

\$112 Billion would be left over for Kingdom
expansion!!!

CONCLUSION:

I asked the Lord how He wanted us to conclude
this service today and I feel led to do it this way:

I am going to stand here (Representing Jesus)
with the offering bucket, and have every person
to pass by to deposit your gifts. As you come by,
I want you to give as if you were giving with
Jesus not only watching, but that He is going to

look at your gift as you give it, and publicly
decide whether it is generous or not. If you are
giving from a device, I want you to come by here
and touch this offering receptacle BEFORE
making your contribution.

